

Kazuki Yano

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Summary

I am a second-year Ph.D. student at Tohoku University working on large language model pre-training, training dynamics, and efficient model scaling, with recent research on multimodal foundation models and adapting text LLMs to new modalities. I have first-author publications at leading venues including **ICLR 2026**, **INTERSPEECH 2026**, **COLM 2025**, and **NAACL 2025**. I have hands-on experience in end-to-end large-scale model training, including pre-training, post-training, and controlled analysis on high-performance compute clusters.

Education

Tohoku University	Sendai, Japan
Ph.D. in Information Science (expected)	2025 – 2028
Supervisor: Jun Suzuki	
M.S. in Information Science	2023 – 2025
Supervisor: Jun Suzuki	

Experience

Amazon Japan G.K. — Research Fellow, Retail Science	Jun 2026 – Sep 2026
SB Intuitions — Research Intern	Nov 2024 – May 2026

- Conducted LLM development on a large compute cluster, spanning pre-training and post-training.
- Studied training efficiency and dynamics through controlled experiments (baselines/ablations) and analysis.

Preferred Networks Inc. — Research Intern	Aug 2024 – Mar 2025
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- Built synthetic-data pipelines for LLM training; evaluated continued pre-training (CPT) and supervised fine-tuning (SFT).
- Quantified effects of data/training choices with baselines/ablations and targeted diagnostics.

Rakuten Group, Inc. — Data Scientist (Part-time)	Jul 2024 – May 2025
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- Studied representation/activation steering for style control via inference-time interventions.
- Evaluated controllability across styles and analyzed internal representations.

LINE Corporation — Research Intern	Aug 2023 – Sep 2023
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- Developed an efficient adversarial-prompt optimization method for safety stress-testing aligned dialogue LMs.

Publications

- **Kazuki Yano**, Jun Suzuki, and Shinji Watanabe. *Adapting Text LLMs to Speech via Multimodal Depth Up-Scaling*. Proceedings of the Annual Conference of the International Speech Communication Association (INTERSPEECH) 2026. [paper](#).
- **Kazuki Yano**, Shun Kiyono, Sosuke Kobayashi, Sho Takase, and Jun Suzuki. *Pre-training LLM without Learning Rate Decay Enhances Supervised Fine-Tuning*. Proceedings of the Fourteenth International Conference on Learning Representations (ICLR) 2026. [paper](#).

- Ryo Fujii, Makoto Morishita, **Kazuki Yano**, and Jun Suzuki. *TimeMachine-bench: A Benchmark on Evaluating Model's Capability on Repository-level Migration Tasks*. Proceedings of the 19th Conference of the European Chapter of the Association for Computational Linguistics (EACL) 2026. [paper](#).
- Keigo Shibata, **Kazuki Yano**, Ryosuke Takahashi, Wataru Ikeda, and Jun Suzuki. *Suppressing Final Layer Hidden State Jumps in Transformer Pretraining*. Findings of the 19th Conference of the European Chapter of the Association for Computational Linguistics (EACL) 2026. [paper](#).
- **Kazuki Yano**, Sho Takase, Sosuke Kobayashi, Shun Kiyono, and Jun Suzuki. *Efficient Construction of Model Family through Progressive Training Using Model Expansion*. Proceedings of the Second Conference on Language Modeling (COLM) 2025. [paper](#).
- Wataru Ikeda, **Kazuki Yano**, Ryosuke Takahashi, Jaesung Lee, Keigo Shibata, and Jun Suzuki. *Layer-wise Importance Analysis of Feed-Forward Networks in Transformer-based Language Models*. Proceedings of the Second Conference on Language Modeling (COLM) 2025. [paper](#).
- **Kazuki Yano**, Takumi Ito, and Jun Suzuki. *STEP: Staged Parameter-Efficient Pre-training for Large Language Models*. Proceedings of the 2025 Conference of the Nations of the Americas Chapter of the Association for Computational Linguistics (NAACL) 2025. [paper](#).
- Keito Kudo, Hiroyuki Deguchi, Makoto Morishita, Ryo Fujii, Takumi Ito, Shintaro Ozaki, Koki Natsumi, Kai Sato, **Kazuki Yano**, Ryosuke Takahashi, Subaru Kimura, Tomomasa Hara, Yusuke Sakai, and Jun Suzuki. *Document-level Translation with LLM Reranking: Team-J at WMT 2024 General Translation Task*. Proceedings of the Ninth Conference on Machine Translation (WMT) 2024. [paper](#).
- **Kazuki Yano**, Takumi Ito, and Jun Suzuki. *STEP: Staged Parameter-Efficient Pre-training for Large Language Models*. Proceedings of the 62nd Annual Meeting of the Association for Computational Linguistics (ACL) Student Research Workshop 2024.

Honors and Awards

- **Outstanding Paper Award** 2025
The 31st Annual Meeting of the Association for Natural Language Processing (NLP 2025)
Awarded to top 14 / 765 submissions
- **BOOST Program for next-generation AI areas (JST)** 2025
BOOST: Broadening Opportunities for Outstanding young researchers and doctoral students in Strategic areas
Research Fellow (subsidized by JST)
- **Encouragement Award** 2025
The 31st Annual Meeting of the Association for Natural Language Processing (NLP 2025)
Awarded to top 20 / 487 eligible submissions
- **Encouragement Award** 2024
The 30th Annual Meeting of the Association for Natural Language Processing (NLP 2024)
Awarded to top 18 / 427 eligible submissions

Academic Service

- Reviewer: ARR, TMLR, ICML, ICASSP.

Skills

- **Tools:** Python, PyTorch, distributed training, Linux, Git, Slurm, Docker/Singularity
- **Language:** Japanese (native), English (professional working proficiency)